

General Education Reflection

My general education courses have shaped the way I approach engineering just as much as my technical classes have. Engineering problems are rarely solved in isolation. They exist inside markets, laws, cultures, and communities, and a solution that ignores those layers usually fails even when the technology works. Courses like Personal Finance, Legal Environment of Business, Introduction to International Studies, Russia Today, and Leadership Theory gave me the vocabulary and the habits of mind to see those layers before I start designing.

The biggest thing I learned is that every design decision carries a cost that someone has to carry. In Personal Finance I learned how budgets, credit, and long term planning actually work, and that changed how I think about tradeoffs in a project. When I evaluate a design now, I think about the total cost over time rather than just whether it meets the specification today. Legal Environment of Business added a second layer to that. Learning about contracts, liability, intellectual property, and regulation made it clear that an engineer does not get to treat the rules as somebody else's problem. A product that works but exposes a company to legal risk is not a finished product.

International Studies and Russia Today pushed my thinking outward. Both courses showed me how different regions approach the same issue in very different ways because of their history, politics, and economic position. That was useful for engineering because the technology I build will not stay in one place. A device or a piece of software designed for one market often gets used somewhere with different infrastructure, different expectations, and different constraints. These classes taught me to ask who the user actually is instead of assuming the user looks like me.

Leadership Theory tied all of this together. It focused on self awareness, communication, and understanding how people respond to direction. Engineering work happens in teams, and the hardest problems are usually not technical. They come from unclear communication, misaligned goals, and people who do not feel heard. Learning to reflect on how I lead and how I follow has made me more useful on a team than any single technical skill.

Looking at contemporary issues, two stand out to me. The first is data privacy and identity security. Personal Finance covered identity theft and how easily personal information can be misused, and that has stayed with me as I work on software and connected devices. Protecting user data is not an optional feature. It is part of the design. The second is the growing economic and technological gap between regions. My international courses made it clear that access to technology is uneven, and that gap affects everything from education to healthcare to economic opportunity. As someone who wants to build technology, I have to think about whether what I build widens that gap or narrows it.

In the end, my general education courses taught me that engineering is a human activity. The technical work gives me a solution. The broader perspective tells me whether that solution is worth building, who it helps, who it might harm, and what it will cost in the long run. I came into college thinking these classes were requirements to get through. I am leaving with the understanding that they are the part of my education that keeps the technical part honest.